Contingent Lives: Visa Status and Distress Among Temporary Migrants

PAA 2027 Submission

Abstract

Temporary visa holders constitute a large but understudied population of documented migrants whose legal status remains conditional on education, employment, or family relationships. Drawing on the concept of liminal legality, this study asks how such conditional legal status may shape psychological distress beyond the deportation threat emphasized in research on undocumented migration. Specifically, we ask how psychological distress is expressed among temporary visa holders and what conditions participants themselves connect to distress, and whether these patterns differ by visa category, gender, and household position. Drawing on 180 semi-structured interviews with F-1, H-1B, H-4, and F-2 visa holders in the United States, we will use structured coding and latent class analysis to identify patterns of distress and the conditions participants associate with them. We will then compare these patterns across visa categories, gender, and household position. By examining both the expression of distress and participants' own attributions of its sources, this study will provide empirical evidence on how conditional legal status is experienced among documented temporary migrants.

[143 words]

Extended Abstract

1. Motivation and Framing

How does legal status shape psychological distress when migrants are formally authorized to remain but lack durable control over their future? Research on immigration and mental health has largely centered on refugee and asylum seekers, emphasizing deportability as a central mechanism of distress (**hamiltonLegalStatusDeportation2023**; **newnhamMentalHealthEffects** Yet research on refugees and asylum seekers suggests that liminal legality—legally recognized but conditional and potentially unstable status—may generate distress through prolonged uncertainty and constrained control over work, family life, and future planning (**menjivarLiminalLegalitySalvadoran2006**; **abregoIncompleteInclusionLegal2015**; **dueItsDamo** Whether similar dynamics characterize temporary migrants remains less understood. Although lawfully present, temporary visa holders are authorized to remain only for bounded periods and under specific conditions: their status may depend on continued enrollment, qualifying employment and employer sponsorship, or a spouse's legal status (**StudentsEmploymentUSCI** **WorkingUnitedStates2025**). Pathways toward permanent residence are likewise uneven and, for many, subject to sponsorship requirements, numerical limits, and prolonged backlogs (**USCISFilingTrends**; **H1BCapSeason2026**; **jacobsPathwaysPermanenceLegal2019**). Temporary legal status may therefore persist for years, combining lawful presence with continuing uncertainty over work, family life, and long-term settlement.

Research on refugees and asylum seekers provides some of the clearest evidence that the security and duration of legal status matter for psychological well-being. Holders of temporary protection visas report higher levels of PTSD, depression, and anxiety than those with permanent status, while changes in legal status predict corresponding changes in psychological symptoms (**nickersonChangeVisaStatus2011**; **momartinComparisonMentalHealth2006**). Other work links legal insecurity to distinct patterns of distress and documents how temporary status produces chronic uncertainty about whether and under what conditions migrants will be able to remain. Together, these findings suggest that the mental-health consequences of legal status may extend beyond exposure to immigration enforcement: prolonged temporariness itself can constrain migrants' ability to plan their lives and exercise control over their futures.

Temporary student, employment, and dependent visa holders provide an important setting in which to examine whether similar dynamics operate outside the refugee and asylum context. These migrants differ substantially from the populations in which liminal legality and legal insecurity have most often been studied: they are formally documented, frequently highly educated, and generally insulated from direct immigration enforcement (**yangOvereducatedUnderpaidCharacteristics2026**). Yet their legal presence remains conditional on institutions and relationships that structure their lives. F-1 status depends on continued enrollment, H-1B status on qualifying employment and employer sponsorship, and F-2 and H-4 status on the legal status of a primary visa holder (**StudentsEmploymentUSCIS2025**; **WorkingUnitedStates2025**). These forms of dependency can persist for years, shaping migrants' ability to work, change careers, establish economic independence, and plan for long-term settlement(**parkTransitionLegalStatus2025**; **bakhshalizadehImpactF2Visa2025**; **thronsonDerivativeDilemmaGendered2024**).

Existing research suggests that these conditions may have consequences for psychological well-being, but evidence remains fragmented across visa categories. Studies of international students link visa-related anxiety to psychological distress; research on H-1B workers similarly identifies uncertainty surrounding legal status and employment as a source of poorer well-being; and research on H-1B/H-4 couples documents depression, anxiety, and stress within visa-dependent households (**lynchInternationalStudentTrauma2024**; **chenSupportingInternationalStudents2024**; **parkImpactChangingNonimmigrant2022**; **chaudhuriHealthWellbeingHighly**; **prasathMarriedAsianIndians2023**). Because these populations are typically studied separately, however, we know much less about whether psychological distress is expressed differently across forms of temporary legal status and whether migrants themselves attribute that distress to different features of their legal and institutional circumstances.

These comparisons are further complicated by the gendered organization of temporary migration. Dependent visas are held disproportionately by women, often married to men holding the primary student or employment visa (**zavodnyNFAPPOLICYBRIEF**). Visa category therefore simultaneously structures legal rights and labor-market access while overlapping with gender and household position (**siddiqiBuildingInvisibleWall2019**; **bordoloiAmStandingStill20** **bakhshalizadehImpactF2Visa2025**). Differences attributed to visa status may consequently reflect legal dependency, gendered household arrangements, or their intersection. Comparing multiple visa categories within a common sample provides an opportunity to examine these dimensions together rather than treating each visa population in isolation.

Drawing on 180 semi-structured interviews with F-1, H-1B, H-4, and F-2 visa holders in the United States, this study will examine how psychological distress is expressed and what conditions participants themselves connect to it. We ask: (1) How do patterns of psychological distress differ across visa category, gender, and household position? (2) What conditions do participants link to distress, and how do these attributions vary across these dimensions?

2. Data and Methods

Data

The study draws on 180 semi-structured interviews with temporary migrants in the United States. Participants were interviewed using a common semi-structured interview guide focused broadly on migration, work and education, family relationships, adaptation to life in the United States, and experiences navigating the immigration system. [TBA: recruitment strategy and sites; fieldwork dates; interview length and language(s); IRB information.]

The sample includes migrants occupying different positions within the temporary visa system, including F-1 students, F-2 dependents, H-1B workers, and H-4 dependents, as well as a smaller number of respondents who had transitioned to permanent residence or held other statuses at the time of interview. Participants vary in gender, household position, employment status, parental status, national origin, and educational background (Table 1). A subset of interviews also comes from members of the same household, including primary and dependent visa holders.

Table 1: Demographic Characteristics of Respondents

Characteristic	Unit	Value	Range
Gender			
Female	%	92	51.1%
Male	%	88	48.9%
Visa Status			
F-1	%	76	42.2%
F-2	%	48	26.7%
H-1B	%	21	11.7%
H-4	%	20	11.1%
Green Card	%	8	4.4%
Other	%	7	3.9%
Country of Origin			
Nigeria	%	31	17.2%
Bangladesh	%	30	16.7%
China	%	20	11.1%
Ghana	%	20	11.1%
Nepal	%	14	7.8%
Brazil	%	10	5.6%
South Africa	%	9	5.0%
India	%	6	3.3%
Other	%	40	22.2%
Educational Attainment			
Doctoral/MD	%	67	37.2%
Master's	%	62	34.4%
Bachelor's	%	48	26.7%
Other	%	2	1.1%
Missing	%	1	0.6%
Employment Status			
Employed	%	85	47.2%
Unemployed	%	68	37.8%
Work-Study	%	25	13.9%
Other	%	2	1.1%
Parent?			
No	%	93	51.7%
Yes	%	83	46.1%
Other	%	4	2.2%
Age			
M (SD)	M (SD)	31.8 (6.0)	Range: 19–60

Note. N = 180.

Method

Because psychological distress came up unprompted in these interviews rather than in response to direct questions, the coding process is built to find every place in a transcript where a participant describes distress or describes one of the specified conditions, and to record whether the participant explicitly connects the two. The distress domains, the condition domains, and what counts as an explicit link are all defined in advance, before any transcript is scanned.

Each transcript is then scanned by two independent automated text-matching methods, each designed to catch passages that resemble example descriptions of a given distress domain or condition; using two methods together, and setting both to flag a passage even when the match is uncertain, reduces the chance that a relevant passage is missed. The same scan also flags places where a participant mentions a condition and a distress close together, or uses connecting language such as "because" or "ever since," as candidates for a possible link between the two.

Every flagged passage will be read and coded in random order for human verification. For each passage, the coder records whether it genuinely describes distress, whether it genuinely describes one of the specified conditions, and, where both are present, whether the participant explicitly links them. Figure 1 summarizes this process.

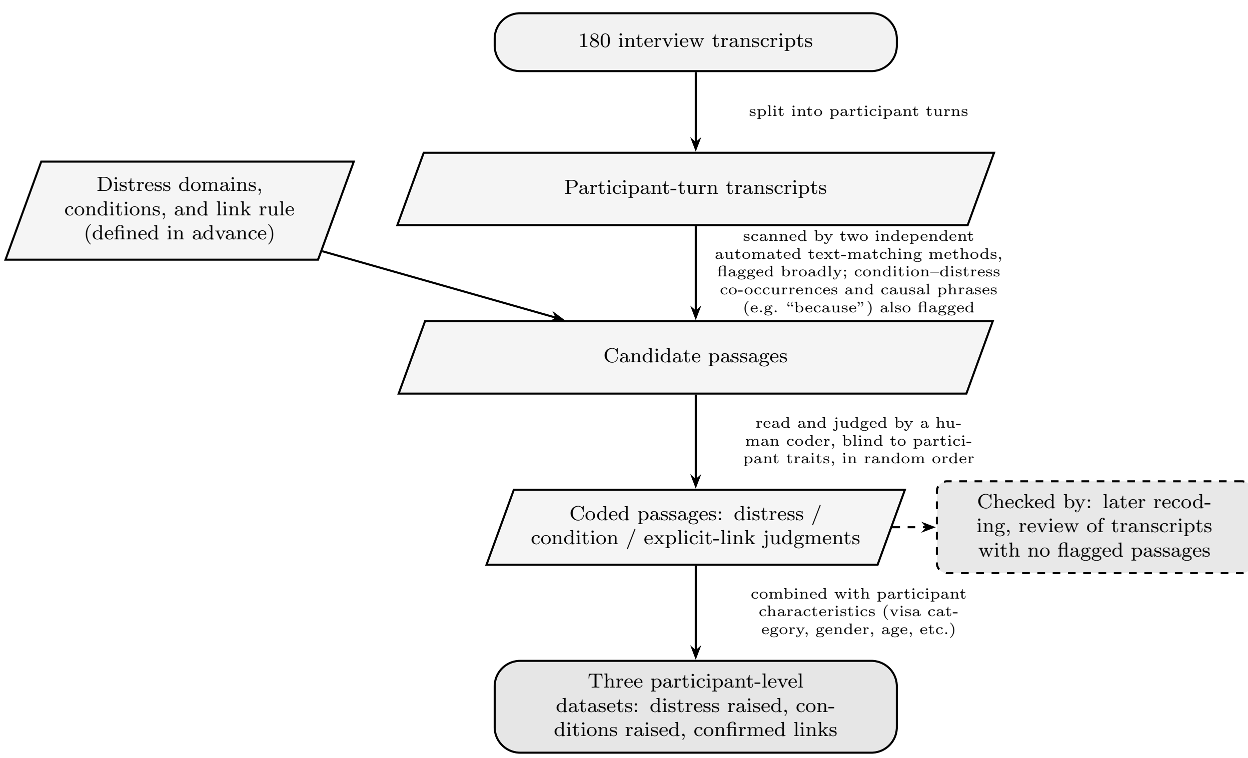

Figure 1: Coding Flow Chart.

The coded passages are combined into three datasets at the participant level: one recording which distress domains each participant raised, one recording which conditions each participant raised, and one recording every confirmed link between a condition and a distress domain, noting whether the condition was something the interview guide specifically asked about or something the participant brought up unprompted. These are merged with participant characteristics collected separately, including visa category, gender, age, time in the United States, national origin, parental status, and household position.

The main analysis compares how often participants in each visa category, gender, and household position raise each distress domain, since this comparison requires no modeling assumptions and speaks most directly to the first research question. Before comparing groups, we check whether participants who talked longer in their interviews simply raised more topics of every kind, since this could create an apparent difference between groups if interview length itself differs by visa category or gender; where it does, interview length is accounted for in the comparison. As a secondary analysis, we test statistically whether participants fall into distinct groups defined by which combination of distress domains they raise, rather than simply differing in how much distress they express overall; where the data instead show only a difference in overall level, we report a simple count of domains raised per participant instead. Finally, the confirmed links between conditions and distress are summarized in a simple chart showing how often each condition is linked to each type of distress, shown separately by visa category and separately for links the interview guide asked about versus links participants raised unprompted, and illustrated with quotations organized by condition.

3. Implications

[TBA: significance; policy implication]

Extended abstract word count: [x]. Tables: 1. Figures: 1.